

44 Polite requests

Use “can,” “could,” and “may” to ask permission to do something, or to ask someone to do something for you. Some constructions are more formal than others.

 **New language** “Can,” “could,” and “may”

Aa Vocabulary Good manners

 **New skill** Asking permission

44.1 KEY LANGUAGE “CAN,” “COULD,” AND “MAY”

Use “can I” plus the verb to make a request. “Can” is mostly used in informal situations.

Ben, **can** I have some popcorn?



Yes, you **can**.

Informal answers use “can” as well.

“Could” replaces “can” for more formal situations, such as in business or to talk to strangers.

Excuse me, **could** I sit here, please?



I’m sorry, but that seat is taken.

Make negative answers more polite by adding “I’m sorry” or “I’m afraid.”

“May” can also be used in formal situations.

May I take your coat?



Yes, thank you.



44.2 FURTHER EXAMPLES “CAN,” “COULD,” AND “MAY”

Can I borrow your pen?



Sure! Here you go.

Excuse me, **could** I have a glass of water?



Of course.

Good evening. **May** I reserve a table for 7pm?



I’m afraid we’re completely full this evening.

TIP

“Could” and “may” are rarely used in short answers to polite questions.

